Kaushal Setu — Frontend UX/UI Workflow & Design Spec

1. Project Context & Design Brief

Event: IMPACT-A-THON 2026, Rotaract Club of SMS Lucknow **Problem Statement:** 202608 — Kaushal Setu: Bridging the Skills-to-Employment Gap **Team deliverable:** a working prototype / proof of concept, presented as a 5-minute pitch + 2-minute Q&A in MPH Hall **My role:** Frontend design — the visual and interaction layer judges will actually see, touch, and judge the team on

The problem, restated: Young people in India — especially outside metro cities — don't know which skills employers actually want, can't easily find training that matches those gaps, and have no simple path from "I don't have the right skills" to "I'm employable." Kaushal Setu needs to turn that fog into four concrete outputs: a skill-assessment questionnaire, a personalised skill-gap report, recommended courses and learning paths, and relevant job, internship, or apprenticeship listings.

What this means for frontend, specifically:

- The interface has to do real explanatory work. Most users arriving at a skill-gap tool won't understand what "skill gap" even means until the product shows them. Onboarding and empty states carry as much weight as the main screens.
- Because the target user (per the problem statement) skews toward first-generation learners, ITI/vocational students, and rural youth — not English-fluent CS students — the design has to work for low digital-literacy, data-constrained, shared-device users, not just for the judges' own laptops.
- Because of the hackathon's "no coding in MPH Hall" rule, everything — every screen, every interaction, every mock data point — must be finished and tested before arrival. There is no live-coding safety net during the demo, so the frontend has to survive a live walkthrough without broken states or "imagine this part works."
- Judges see this project for roughly five minutes. The frontend's job is to make the idea and the impact legible almost instantly, through hierarchy and content, not just through polish.

Design goals this spec is solving for:

1. A realistic, end-to-end interface a judge could click through live, not a static mockup.
2. A visual language that signals "built for Bharat," not "built for a Silicon Valley demo day."
3. A structure the team can actually finish before the hackathon, scoped honestly against remaining time.

4. Every design decision traceable back to the judging rubric (see Section 9).

2. Target Users

A senior designer doesn't design "for youth" in the abstract — the problem statement itself names several overlapping groups. Below are three working personas built from the problem statement plus current research on how young Indians outside major metros actually access the internet. Treat these as the three people in your head every time you make a screen decision.

Persona A — "Fresh Graduate, Unsure Niche" (Priya, 22, Lucknow)

- B.Com graduate from a tier-2 city college; comfortable with English and Hindi; owns a mid-range Android phone with a steady but metered data plan.
- Goal: wants to know which skill to specialise in and whether she's actually job-ready.
- Frustration: has browsed job portals but feels overwhelmed by jargon-heavy listings and doesn't know how to close the gap between her degree and a real job.
- Design implication: needs a credible, professional visual language and a clear "here's exactly what to do next" report — not a children's app, but not an intimidating enterprise dashboard either.

Persona B — "ITI / Vocational Trainee" (Rahul, 20, semi-urban UP)

- Completed, or is mid-way through, an ITI diploma; Hindi-first reader, reads English haltingly.
- Goal: wants to know which certifications or short courses actually lead to interviews, and wants apprenticeships near home, not just in metros.
- Frustration: most job portals are English-only, text-dense, and don't filter by trade or distance.
- Design implication: heavy reliance on icons plus short bilingual labels, large tap targets, and location/trade filtering as a first-class feature, not a buried option.

Persona C — "Rural First-Generation Smartphone User" (Sunita, 19, village near Barabanki)

- First in her family to own a smartphone; often shares the family device; patchy 4G, limited data; low confidence with multi-step forms.
- Goal: wants to understand, in the simplest possible terms, "what work can I do, and how do I learn it."
- Frustration: text-heavy forms and multi-step flows cause drop-off before she ever reaches a result.

- Design implication: this persona should set the floor for the whole interface. If a screen doesn't work for Sunita, it needs simplifying, even if Priya and Rahul would have been fine with it.

Why this matters, with numbers: rural India now accounts for the majority of the country's active internet base — recent industry tracking puts rural users at roughly 548 million, about 57% of all active internet users nationally, and growing several times faster than urban adoption. A meaningful share of that access is through someone else's device rather than a personally owned one, and that share is heavily concentrated in rural areas. Mobile teledensity tells a similar story: urban India is past 125 connections per 100 people (multi-device households), while rural India sits closer to 59 — a real connectivity gap, not just a literacy one. Practically, this means the frontend should never assume a fast connection, a personal always-logged-in device, or confident English reading, because for a large share of the actual target users, none of those are safe assumptions.

Research from Microsoft Research India and Google's "Next Billion Users" work on designing for low-literacy, first-time smartphone users in India converges on a few rules worth holding onto for every screen in Section 6:

- Literal, representational icons beat abstract or minimal ones. Low-literacy users consistently pointed to the most literal version of an icon in testing, not the cleanest one.
- Icon plus short label beats icon-only. Text-only interfaces are close to unusable for first-time, low-literacy users.
- Design for shared devices and interrupted sessions, not a single always-logged-in owner. Don't lose a user's progress if the app is closed mid-assessment.
- Treat data cost as a real constraint. Don't make heavy images or animation the only way information is conveyed.

3. UX Design Process

A senior designer doesn't start with screens, they start with a process, even a compressed one. Here is the workflow adapted for a hackathon timeline where most "research" has to happen in hours, not weeks.

Phase 1 — Discover (compressed field research). Instead of real user interviews, mine the problem statement itself plus adjacent real-world products: Skill India Digital / Skill India Digital Hub (the Government of India's own skilling and employment platform), and mainstream course and job-card patterns from platforms like LinkedIn Learning, Coursera, and Naukri. The goal isn't to copy them, it's to borrow what already works for this exact user base and government-adjacent trust context, since Kaushal Setu is pitching a civic/social-impact solution, not a consumer startup.

Phase 2 — Define (structure before pixels). Lock the information architecture (Section 4) and the primary user flow (Section 5) before anyone opens a design tool or writes HTML. This is the single highest-leverage hour of the whole project. Every hour spent here saves three hours of rebuilding screens later.

Phase 3 — Design (low-fi, then system, then high-fi).

1. Low-fidelity wireframes for all 11 screens (see Section 4) — fast, disposable, ugly on purpose.
2. Lock the design system (Section 7) once, before building any real screen, so every screen after that is assembly, not invention.
3. Build high-fidelity screens in build order (Section 8), reusing one or two layout shells across the whole app rather than hand-crafting every screen.

Phase 4 — Deliver (prototype and pitch rehearsal). Wire up the click-through path end-to-end, remove dead links and placeholder text, and rehearse the pitch on the actual device and browser window that will be used in MPH Hall, with a backup copy carried separately, per the event's own rules.

Time-boxing suggestion for whatever time is left: roughly 10% Discover, 15% Define, 25% wireframes plus design system, 40% high-fidelity build, 10% pitch rehearsal and bug-bash. If time is very short, compress Discover and Define, but don't skip them. A well-structured 6-screen prototype beats an 11-screen prototype with a confusing flow.

4. Information Architecture

Below is the full sitemap. Not every screen needs to be pixel-perfect before the hackathon (see Section 8 for MVP versus stretch scoping), but the team should agree on all 11 now, so nothing gets designed in a way that boxes out a screen needed later.

```
Kaushal Setu
├── 1. Landing / Home
├── 2. Onboarding — Language & Role Selection
├── 3. Sign Up / Log In
├── 4. Skill Assessment (multi-step questionnaire)
├── 5. Skill Gap Report (results)
├── 6. Course Recommendations
│    └── 6a. Course Detail (modal or sub-page)
├── 7. Job & Internship Listings
│    └── 7a. Job/Internship Detail (modal or sub-page)
├── 8. Profile / Dashboard
└── 9. About / Impact
```

Why each page earns its place:

- **Landing** — the first impression for both judges and users; must explain the "what" and "who for" in under ten seconds.
- **Onboarding (language + role)** — given the persona spread in Section 2, letting a user self-identify as student, ITI/vocational, or job-seeker, and pick Hindi or English up front, is cheap to build and does real credibility work with judges, because it's a visible answer to "how is this inclusive?"
- **Sign Up / Log In** — can be a lightweight mock (name plus phone number, no real authentication needed). Judges care that the flow exists, not that it's production-secure.
- **Skill Assessment** — the core input mechanism; the screen judges are most likely to interact with live.
- **Skill Gap Report** — the core "aha" output; the moment the product's value becomes visible.
- **Course Recommendations** — the first of two "what do I do about it" screens.
- **Job/Internship Listings** — the second, and arguably the most socially impactful, screen. It closes the loop from skill gap to actual opportunity.
- **Profile/Dashboard** — shows persistence and progress over time, which signals "sustainability" to judges, a named rubric item.
- **About/Impact** — a short, judge-facing page stating the mission and intended social impact in plain language; useful for the pitch, not just the user.

If the team is short on build time, Section 8 shows exactly which of these 11 screens can be cut to a static or simplified state without weakening the pitch.